

GAME-MASTER'S SETUP GUIDE • REMOVE THESE LEAVES BEFORE SHE ARRIVES

MINUTE ONE

HANDED TO HER: the letter and the Milk Crate painting.
The letter gives her the address sarahs.quest.

OUT IN THE OPEN: the nine printables, the flyer, the lemons,
the knife AND the scale, The Prophet, the locked suitcase.

OPEN AT THE SAME TIME • two lines, either order

Milk Crate painting, back → Ed Sheeran

Stars and Their Notes → The Barista's Hornpipe, two notes

Parlour Songbook, those two shapes → 12 and 15

Concordance + The Prophet, pages 12 and 15 → CORN BREAD

Receipt Book, cornbread → a game of backgammon

BACKGAMMON SET
Plate II • the Patricia painting

Put the knife on the scale → 79 g

Knife Catalogue, 79 g → No. 9, the Lemonade Knife

Cut the lemons open → the Joker

Cartomancer's Guide, the Joker → in the Dutch oven

DUTCH OVEN
Plate I

OPENS WHEN THE MUSIC LINE IS DONE

Patricia painting → Register → a small painted egg...

WINGSPAN BOX
Hamlet painting • fairy painting • a Queen of Hearts

THREE AT ONCE • any order

Queen of Hearts → Cartomancer's Guide
→ the back of the upstairs toilet

TOILET CISTERN
the BLACK key → the suitcase

Hamlet → Hamnet → Chloé Zhao
→ Register, Chloe → a jar of sweets

THE CANDY JAR
blue-light pen • Abyssinia & Gleaners paintings

Fairy houses → Shirley
→ Register → a bottle kept for company

LIQUOR CABINET
the Pig-Pen Alphabet sheet

THE LOCK • needs a piece from every line

Abyssinia painting + pigpen sheet → sarahs.quest,
the Ethiopian flag is Plate VII, turned over → HALF PAST THREE

Flyer → bathroom. Blue-light pen + pigpen sheet
→ under ALIEN BLUES: OPEN WHAT YOU SIT ON TO BREATHE

INSIDE THE MEDITATION CUSHION
the card: DW₅OY₇ H₃W VKYJ LKRWQ

THE WHEEL: pin Plate II on Plate I, set the hands to 3:30, decode the card
DW₅OY₇ H₃W VKYJ LKRWQ = BEHIND THE MANY FACES

BEHIND THE FRAMED PHOTO PUZZLE • the DARK BLUE key

BLACK key, from the cistern, opens the SUITCASE
early on. Inside: the backpack, still locked.

DARK BLUE key opens the BACKPACK
the prize

Nothing can be shortcut: the card is unreadable without both plates and the time, and those come from three different places.

PLAIN ENGLISH FOR THE THINGS WITH ODD NAMES

THE CONCORDANCE

The one-page sheet headed "A Reader's Concordance" with "The Prophet, by Kahlil Gibran" printed under the masthead. It gives one word-counting rule for each of 84 pages. She needs a real copy of The Prophet to use it; the sheet itself names the book, so put the book on the shelf among others and nothing more is needed.

PLATE I AND PLATE II

The two circles on the cipher-wheel pages. Plate I, "The Dial", is the big one with clock numerals round the rim. Plate II, "The Hands", is the smaller one with two clock hands printed on it. Cut both out. Push a brad (split pin) through the centre of Plate I and tape it there; she pins Plate II on top and turns it until the hands read 3:30.

PIGPEN

A cipher where each letter is drawn as the walls of the box it sits in. The printed Pig-Pen Alphabet sheet is the key. The only pigpen you write by hand is the wall; the flags' pigpen is already on the website.

WHEEL SYMBOLS

Ordinary letters and digits that only mean something once the wheel is set. You copy them onto the cushion card exactly as printed below.

LOCK AND LOAD, IN THIS ORDER, SO NO KEY ENDS UP LOCKED INSIDE ITS OWN BOX

1. Put the prize in the backpack. Close it and padlock it. Its key is **DARK BLUE**.
2. Put the backpack inside the suitcase. Close the suitcase and padlock it. Its key is **BLACK**.
3. Stand the suitcase somewhere she will see it all evening. It is meant to taunt.
4. Hide **BLACK** in a ziplock in the toilet cistern. She reaches it mid-game, opens the suitcase, and finds the backpack still locked. That is the moment the evening turns.
5. Tape **DARK BLUE** flat to the back of the framed photo puzzle. Masking tape, pressed down so it cannot rattle. Nothing points here until the wheel is decoded.
6. **PURPLE** and **LIGHT BLUE** are not used. Put them in a drawer.

Two locks is the whole scheme. The wheel exists to produce the second key, so it cannot be skipped.

EVERY HIDING PLACE AND WHAT GOES IN IT

PLACE	CONTENTS
HER HANDS	The welcome letter and the Milk Crate painting. Nothing is hidden on the painting; its back just carries the written clue.
OUT IN THE OPEN	The nine printables scattered about; the flyer on the fridge; a bowl of lemons, one loaded; the knife and the kitchen scale on the counter; The Prophet on the shelf among many books; the locked suitcase
BACKGAMMON SET	Plate II; the Patricia painting
WINGSPAN BOX	The Hamlet painting; the fairy painting; a real Queen of Hearts playing card
TOILET CISTERN	The BLACK key in a ziplock bag. Nothing else, ever. No paper, no paintings.
THE CANDY JAR	The blue-light pen; the Abyssinia painting; the Gleaners painting. Roll the paintings or lay them under the jar if they will not fit inside.
LIQUOR CABINET	The Pig-Pen Alphabet key sheet
DUTCH OVEN	Plate I, with a brad (split pin) taped to it
BATHROOM WALL OR MIRROR	ALIEN BLUES in dry-erase marker; the pigpen glyphs from the tracing sheet in invisible ink beneath
INSIDE THE MEDITATION CUSHION	The cipher card, in a small envelope, tucked just inside the zip where a hand will meet it
BEHIND THE FRAMED PHOTO PUZZLE	The DARK BLUE key, taped flat to the back of the frame. Nothing points here until the wheel is decoded, so it is never searched.
SUITCASE	The backpack. The suitcase itself is padlocked with the BLACK lock and left in plain sight all evening.
BACKPACK	The prize. Padlocked with the DARK BLUE lock. All six paintings are placed elsewhere; none is in here.

EVERYTHING YOU WRITE BY HAND • THERE ARE ONLY FIVE THINGS

1 • THE WELCOME LETTER. Your words, your handwriting. It must do three jobs and no more: give her the address [sarahs.quest](#); warn her that some things she finds will not make sense on the day she finds them; and end with a line in your own voice. Do not explain any puzzle. Do not mention the suitcase. If you are stuck for an opening: *“There are six paintings in this apartment and every one of them is a question. You will need a scale, a knife, a pin, and more patience than I deserve.”*

2 • THE SIX PAINTING BACKS. Write these on the quarter-sheet frames and clip or tape one to each painting.

MILK CRATE — *The famous man we always see here, who is not him.*

PATRICIA’S — *Just the name. Look her up.*

HAMLET — *We saw the film of this play. Whose film was it? Look her up by her first name.*

FAIRY HOUSES — *What was the family name of the one who lived here? Look her up.*

ABYSSINIA — *This country has another name now. Find its colours at [sarahs.quest](#), and turn them over.*

GLEANERS — *The café sits in a market named for a country. Its colours are at [sarahs.quest](#) too.*

3 • THE WALL. In dry-erase marker, large: ALIEN BLUES. Directly beneath it, in the invisible-ink pen, copy the shapes from the tracing sheet two pages back. Each shape has its letter printed above it in grey; copy the shapes only, never the letters. They read OPEN WHAT YOU SIT ON TO BREATHE. Test a corner first: glass and glazed tile wipe clean, grout and stone do not. The mirror is the safest surface in the room.

4 • THE CIPHER CARD. Any scrap of paper. In capitals, exactly, with the spaces where they are:

DW5OY7 H5W VKYJ LKRWQ

Put it in a small envelope. On the envelope write: *This will mean nothing until the hour is set.* Tuck it just inside the cushion’s zip, where a hand will meet it straight away.

5 • THREE HINT ENVELOPES (optional, but they save the evening). Seal three envelopes and label them *If you are stuck on the music*, *If you are stuck on the knife*, and *If you are stuck at the very end*. Inside each, one sentence: *Everything you need is at [sarahs.quest/hints.html](#) — and I will not think less of you.*

WHAT YOU DO NOT WRITE

The flags’ pigpen is already on the website. The register, the card guide, the concordance, the songbook, the knife catalogue and the recipe book are printed and final. The only cipher you draw by hand is the wall.

THE FIVE TESTS, BEFORE SHE ARRIVES

1. **The knife.** Put your real knife on your real scale. It must read 79 g. The nearest catalogue entries are 58 g and 99 g, so you have about 14 g of slack either way. If it is wildly off, pick a different knife.
2. **The book.** Open your copy of *The Prophet*. Page 12, fourth word of the first line, must be **corn**. Page 15, the first sentence beginning “Give”, sixth word, must be **bread**. Editions differ and this is the single most likely thing to break.
3. **The wall.** Shine the blue-light pen on your writing. The shapes must show clearly. Then wipe a corner to be certain it comes off.
4. **The wheel.** Cut both plates, pin them, set the hands to half past three, and decode the cipher card yourself. It must read BEHIND THE MANY FACES.
5. **The website.** Open sarahs.quest on your phone. Tap Plate VII, the green-yellow-red flag with the blue disc. The pigpen on its back must read HALF PAST THREE.

THE ORDER TO SET THE ROOM UP

1. Lock the backpack, put it in the suitcase, lock the suitcase, stand it in the open.
2. Hide the two keys: BLACK in the cistern, DARK BLUE behind the framed puzzle.
3. Place all six paintings: Milk Crate in her envelope; Patricia in the backgammon set; Hamlet and the fairy houses in the Wingspan box with the Queen of Hearts; Abyssinia and Gleaners with the candy jar. None goes in the backpack.
4. Plate II in the backgammon set. Plate I in the Dutch oven. Pig-pen sheet in the liquor cabinet.
5. Load one lemon with the Joker and set the bowl out. Knife and scale on the counter.
6. Cipher card into the cushion. Write the wall. Flyer on the fridge.
7. Scatter the printed sheets around the room. *The Prophet* onto the shelf among other books.
8. Tear the last six leaves out of the printed packet and hide them from yourself.

IF SHE STALLS

sarahs.quest/hints.html holds eighteen predicaments, each with a nudge, then a firmer nudge, then the answer outright. It is linked in a box at the top of the flags page, so she can reach it on her own and you never have to be the one who gives it away. Or just tell her; you are allowed.